

The pills called PDE5 inhibitors treat **erectile dysfunction (ED)**. One of them, tadalafil, also eases the urinary symptoms of an **enlarged prostate**. The four are **sildenafil (Viagra)**, **tadalafil (Cialis)**, **varденаfil** and **avanafil**. They help your body make an erection when you are aroused. They do not cause one on their own.

## How It Works

These medicines **relax the blood vessels** in the penis so blood can flow in. They work **only with sexual arousal**. Tadalafil also relaxes muscle in the prostate and bladder, so a low daily dose can ease urinary symptoms a little.

## What to Expect

- **Sildenafil and vardenafil** are taken about an hour before sex. **Avanafil** can work in as little as 15–30 minutes.
- **Tadalafil** lasts longer, up to about 36 hours. It can also be taken as a **low dose every day**.
- A large or fatty meal can **delay** sildenafil and vardenafil. Tadalafil and avanafil are not much affected by food.
- No one pill works best for everyone. You and your team choose by timing, cost and side effects.
- Using the pill the right way matters. If it does not work, try it several more times, and ask your team about your dose, before deciding it has failed.

## Learn the Terms

### PDE5 inhibitor

The group of pills, such as sildenafil and tadalafil, used for ED.

### Erectile dysfunction (ED)

Trouble getting or keeping an erection firm enough for sex.

### Nitrates

Heart and chest-pain medicines that must never be taken with these pills.

### As-needed or daily

Taken before sex, or a low dose every day.

### BPH

An enlarged prostate. Tadalafil also treats its urinary symptoms.

### Priapism

An erection that lasts 4 hours or more. It is an emergency.

**The rule that matters most:** Never take these pills with **nitrates** (such as nitroglycerin or isosorbide for chest pain), with “poppers” (amyl nitrite), or with riociguat. Together they can cause a **dangerous drop in blood pressure**. Tell every doctor and nurse that you take a PDE5 inhibitor.

## How to Take It

- Take it **as prescribed**: before sex, or every day.
- Take no more than one dose in 24 hours.
- Do not add a second ED pill, such as sildenafil on top of daily tadalafil, on your own.

## Important Safety

- If you take an **alpha blocker** for the prostate or other blood pressure medicines, you may get dizzy. Your team may start you on a lower dose.
- If you have **heart disease**, check with your doctor that sex and these pills are safe for you.
- Heavy drinking adds to dizziness.
- Tell your team about kidney or liver disease, eye disease, and all your medicines. Some, such as the HIV medicine ritonavir, change your dose.

## Common Side Effects

- Headache, **flushing**, stuffy nose, indigestion
- Back or muscle aches, mostly with tadalafil
- A short-lived change in color vision with sildenafil

### Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Side effects that bother you
- A pill that does not work after several tries

### Go to an emergency department if:

- An erection lasts **4 hours** or more, even if it does not hurt
- You suddenly lose vision or hearing. Stop the pill.
- You have chest pain or faint. Tell the staff which pill you took and when.
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

## Three Things to Remember

1. These pills help you get an erection when you are aroused. They do not work on their own.
2. **Never take them with nitrates or poppers.**
3. Give the pill a fair trial, used the right way, before deciding it does not work.